National
Qualifications
2026

2026 Spanish

Listening and Discursive Writing

Advanced Higher

Question Paper Finalised Marking Instructions

These marking instructions have been prepared by examination teams for use by Qualifications Scotland appointed markers when marking external course assessments.

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General marking principles for Advanced Higher Spanish Listening

Always apply these general principles. Use them in conjunction with the detailed marking instructions, which identify the key features required in candidates' responses.

(a) Always use positive marking. This means candidates accumulate marks for the demonstration of relevant skills, knowledge and understanding; marks are not deducted for errors or omissions.

(b) If a candidate response does not seem to be covered by either the principles or detailed marking instructions and you are uncertain how to assess it, you must seek guidance from your team leader.

(c) Award a mark for each answer. Marks are not transferable between questions and the answers for each question must come from the item.

(d) Award marks according to the accuracy and relevance of the candidate's answers. Award marks where the answer is accurate but expressed in their own words.

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Marking instructions for each question - Listening

Item 1

Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
					Do not accept:
1.	(a)		• (young people) spend more and more time in front of their mobiles/computers/screens	**1**	more time on screens than on computers most of their time more time
	(b)		• more than three hours • double the recommended amount **Any 1 from 2**	**1**	
	(c)		• chatting/talking/texting with friends on social media about their weekend plans • following their favourite influencers	**2**	 celebrities
	(d)		• sleeping the recommended 8 hours • doing 30 minutes physical activity/exercise • reading books **Any 2 from 3**	**2**	

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Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
					Do not accept:
	(e)		• they are aware of the dangers • they haven't received any training/guidance/education on how to deal with these dangers • their parents rarely monitor their online activity **Any 2 from 3**	**2**	formation
	(f)		• (implementing) a policy to protect young people on the internet • it includes an age verification tool for online platforms	**2**	law

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Item 2

Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
					Do not accept:
2.	(a)		• 94% of Spanish young people use social media regularly • they are hooked on/addicted to their phones	**2**	children technology
	(b)		• to promote social awareness • to find out what is happening in the world	**2**	social conscience to inform about what is in the world
	(c)	(i)	• young people fall into the habit of spending hours obsessively on their phones • they watch silly/stupid video clips • they lose track/sense of time	**3**	
		(ii)	• the negative impact that can affect emotional/mental and physical wellbeing • they have a greater/increased feeling of loneliness/they feel more isolated/lonely	**2**	

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Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
					Do not accept:
	(d)	(i)	• young people think it is just a way to have fun	**1**	it is the only way to have fun
		(ii)	• (young people) find it hard to concentrate in class	**1**	
		(iii)	• establish healthy limits • encourage face to face interactions	**2**	
	(e)		• in a language classroom, pupil have access to fantastic opportunities • you can read today's news in another language **Any 1 from 2**	**1**	
	(f)		• it allows individualised learning so pupils can work at own pace • some (educational) apps increase motivation • pupils are encouraged to complete more complicated tasks • it improves their self esteem **Any 3 from 4**	**3**	games self-confidence

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Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
					Do not accept:
	(g)		• educational online games • it encourages competition and collaboration with their classmates	**2**	increases
	(h)		• we have to embrace it/welcome it • we have to accept that they are a part of everyday life • we have to be careful **Any 1 from 3**	**1**	

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General marking principles for Advanced Higher Spanish Discursive Writing

This information is provided to help you understand the general principles you must apply when marking candidate responses to questions in this paper. These principles must be read in conjunction with the detailed marking instructions, which identify the key features required in candidate responses.

(a) Marks for each candidate response must **always** be assigned in line with these general marking principles and the detailed marking instructions for this assessment.

(b) Marking should always be positive. This means that, for each candidate response, marks are accumulated for the demonstration of relevant skills, knowledge and understanding: they are not deducted from a maximum on the basis of errors or omissions.

(c) If a specific candidate response does not seem to be covered by either the principles or detailed marking instructions, and you are uncertain how to assess it, you must seek guidance from your team leader.

(d) Marking should be holistic. There may be strengths and weaknesses in the piece of writing; markers should focus as far as possible on the strengths, taking account of weaknesses only where they significantly detract from the overall impression.

Three main aspects of the piece of writing should be considered:
(i) content
(ii) accuracy
(iii) language resource – variety, range, structures

(e) Using the pegged marks table, the marker should first select the row of the table in which the descriptors most closely match the candidate's piece of writing. Once that row has been identified, the assessor should follow this guidance:

- If the evidence largely matches the descriptors across all of the aspects of the work, award the higher of the two available marks
- If the evidence largely matches the descriptors across most of the aspects of the work, award the lower of the two marks available

(f) If markers are in doubt about which of two adjacent rows to select: select the upper row and award the lower pegged mark in that row.

(g) Markers can award the highest pegged mark (40) for writing even if there are minor errors. These should not detract from the overall impression.

(h) Candidates are instructed to write 250-300 words. The general and detailed marking instructions should be applied even where the length of the piece of writing falls outside this range.

(i) Markers should support candidates' use of their preferred use of gender-neutral nouns, pronouns and adjectives when referring to themselves and others in the assessment of writing. Using gender-neutral pronouns, nouns and adjectives, whether by adding punctuation, asterisks or using alternative spellings is now a common feature of inclusive language.

A candidate can opt to use masculine, feminine or gender-neutral adjective agreements throughout their writing or performance-talking assessment(s), where appropriate to the language. It is important to note that candidates must use their preferred pronouns and adjectives in a consistent manner and adhere to associated conventions of adjectival agreement where appropriate. Where gender-neutral nouns, pronouns and adjectives are used, it is important that candidates are marked on this based on its consistent use.

If you are uncertain or have queries about how to assess specific aspects of candidate response, you must seek guidance from your team leader or Principal Assessor.

Marking instructions – Discursive writing

Mark	Content	Accuracy	Language resource: variety, range, structures
40 or 36	• The essay is well structured and all aspects are relevant to the title • The topic is addressed fully, in a balanced way • Overall this comes over as a comprehensive, competent, well thought-out response to the task which reads naturally	• The language is characterised by a high degree of accuracy and may show some flair • A comprehensive range of verbs is used accurately and tenses are consistent and accurate • There is evidence of confident handling of all aspects of grammar and spelling • Some minor errors need not detract from the overall very good impression	• The language used is mostly complex and sophisticated • There is a wide range of structures and vocabulary appropriate to advanced higher • There is a comprehensive range of verbs/verb forms and tenses • There is good use of less common adjectives, adverbs, prepositional phrases and, where appropriate, word order • There is extensive use of co-ordinating conjunctions and subordinate clauses throughout the writing • The language flows well and ideas and opinions are expressed effectively
32 or 28	• The essay has a good sense of structure and most aspects are relevant to the title • The topic is addressed well • The content is clear and well thought out	• The language is clearly comprehensible throughout and fairly free of serious errors in areas appropriate to advanced higher • A range of verbs is used accurately and tenses are generally consistent and accurate • Other parts of speech are used accurately • There are few serious errors in spelling and/or punctuation	• The language used is generally complex and sophisticated • Contains a good range of vocabulary and structures appropriate to advanced higher • The candidate uses a good range of verbs/verb forms and tenses • There is good use of co-ordinating conjunctions and subordinate clauses throughout the writing • Ideas and opinions are expressed effectively

Mark	Content	Accuracy	Language resource: variety, range, structures
24 or 20	• The essay has some sense of structure and most aspects have some relevance to the title • The topic is addressed adequately • The content is mostly clear	• The less complex language may be mostly accurate. However, in places, where the candidate attempts to use complex and sophisticated language, this may be less successful • The verbs are generally correct, but the range of verbs and tenses is limited • Spelling and punctuation are generally correct but there may be a few errors in some parts of speech – personal pronouns, gender of nouns, adjective endings, cases, singular/plural confusion • Overall, there is more correct than incorrect and there is the impression that the candidate can handle tenses	• There are some examples of complex and sophisticated language • Contains a reasonable range of vocabulary and structures appropriate to advanced higher • There is a limited range of verbs/verb forms and tenses • There are some successful attempts to use co-ordinating conjunctions and subordinate clauses. • Ideas and opinions are expressed adequately • There is some dictionary misuse
16 or 12	• The essay is lacking in structure and less than half of the aspects have any relevance to the title • The topic is addressed but in a limited way • The content is limited and may be presented as a single paragraph	• The language is insufficiently accurate to convey meaning clearly and consistently • Ability to use verbs and form tenses accurately is inconsistent. There may be confusion between the singular and plural form of verbs • Although basic structures are used accurately, control of the language structure at times deteriorates significantly • There are errors in other parts of speech – gender of nouns, cases, singular/plural confusion – and in spelling and, where appropriate, word order. Several errors are serious • Overall there is more incorrect than correct	• There is limited use of complex and sophisticated language • Contains a limited range of vocabulary and/or structures appropriate to advanced higher • There is inconsistency in the use of verbs/verb forms and tenses • There are few successful attempts to use co-ordinating conjunctions and subordinate clauses • There may be examples of unidiomatic translation from English and/or examples of dictionary misuse

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Mark	Content	Accuracy	Language resource: variety, range, structures
8 or 4	• The essay is unstructured and few aspects are relevant to the title • The topic is not fully addressed • The content is very limited	• The language is almost completely inaccurate throughout the writing and there is little control of language structure • Most of the verbs are incorrect. There is little evidence of tense control • Most basic structures are not used accurately and control of the language structure generally deteriorates significantly • There are frequent errors in other parts of speech — personal pronouns, gender of nouns, cases, singular/plural confusion, prepositions. Overall there is more incorrect than correct	• There is little use, if any, of complex and sophisticated language • The essay contains a very limited range of vocabulary and structures appropriate to advanced higher • The candidate may not cope with more than one or two basic verbs/verb forms and tenses • Some sentences may not be understood by a sympathetic native speaker • There are examples of mother tongue interference and serious dictionary misuse
0	• The essay is unstructured and/or irrelevant • The candidate is unable to address the topic	• The language is seriously inaccurate throughout the writing and there is almost no control of language structure • Very few words are written correctly in the modern language	• There is no evidence of complex and sophisticated language • There may be several examples of mother tongue interference • Very little is intelligible to a sympathetic native speaker • There may be several examples of serious dictionary misuse

[END OF MARKING INSTRUCTIONS]

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